

Communications Subcommittee Notes - February 2, 2021

Member Graham:

Called meeting to order at 5:04 PM - to discuss the Strategic District wide plan & Middle School Orientation

Roll Call - Member McLaughlin & Member Kreatz - 3-0

In discussing the Strategic Plan - Began it prior to covid - but obviously other items took over conversation. So where are we? How are we planning to continue this discussion/process?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent:

Presented Strategic Plan draft - Mission/Vision - safe & healthy learning environment - Core Values: Achievement, Collaboration, Equity & Support

Our large bucketed areas - Objectives & Initiatives

Fostering Student Growth & Achievement

Fostering Collaborative Relationships

Fostering Equitable Learning Environment

Early indicators of success

All educators updated on DESE frameworks - constant collaboration with DESE

Professional Development - Evidence Based responses, productive struggle, academic discourse, access for all and feedback

Foss Science - Elementary - timelines for all different pieces being added

Implementation of new Social Studies curriculum - K 12

Rubrics to select elementary literacy programs & then implement elementary Literacy program

Math curriculum is from 2015 - Ms. Khan will be looking into piloting new math programs

Determine protocols

Bias in curriculum

Peer educators visit around district

Dr. Cushing - Remarks regarding Strategic Plan...

Fostering equitable learning environment - and Safe & Supportive - tight and cohesive work, use and refine safety protocols - the security and support procedures for our organization - not published widely, as don't want to give a game plan to community -

Investigated key card system - to improve safety in buildings

Reviewed threat assessments - went to training -to understand the threat assessment process

Examined building infrastructure to support safe environments

Looking forward to getting back to it all, rather than just dealing with covid

Dr. Edouard-Vincent continued ...

Staff professional development - co teaching, SEL, Responsive classroom, Dyslexia EL, Special Education

Promoting health and wellness of the students - especially this year - with the isolation and the inability to have face to face discussions

Culture & Climate for our district - including data collection - what is our capacity to provide positive climate & culture?

Member Graham...

When we left off, this document was presented to SC and forwarded to this subcommittee

We need to look at the right ways to engage the community in this document

Mission/Vision - a lot of words - does it resonate with the community at large?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent ...

When we were working on this document - it is a lot of words - but what will we prioritize? Learning & instruction - how can this work? Collaboration pre-covid - it was: who's your buddy? Students would go work in a corner of a room - to promote that collaborative learning - we want it to be done in an equitable fashion - safe and supportive learning environment - be who you are and learn and grow and challenge - now it means, masks, hand sanitizers, plastic shields, - Jan of 2020 version - we had already started the work a year prior to that - we tried to bring it all together in one place - we have so many initiatives in the schools - We needed to take all the information and house in one place - we know now that living in the covid era, how many shifts we've had to make, what does it look like in covid - circles on the floor, tape and limit large groups - so those are pieces we want to go back and infuse into this document - this particular strategic plan is based on feedback from subcommittees - Today, all communications are now translated - talking apps for EL families - Member McLaughlin - proposed and pushed for closed captioning being added in - it is all additional necessary layers of communication - Two way communication

In discussing our website - the present website is a year old - we realize it will still need to be adjusted, a work in progress. However, the previous website hadn't been updated in over 10 years

What did we want to do to improve communications? That we all speak the same language within the Mustang community - the Strategic plan is a living document, it's not set in stone

We can revisit Mission/Vision & update it to 2021 - but in terms of running the district, we all have to be speaking the same language - For example, we are working on X, Y and Z, and that is found in the Strategic Plan

Member Graham ...

Reopening Task Force - community groups - was very important - need action items for strategic plan - How do we engage the community in this discussion? We have some work to do there Part of the value of the Strategic Plan, in support of it, why are we doing and where does it fit? These are our priorities...so our budget presentation should be prepared to reflect those values. For example, if it is deemed the website becomes the most important thing. Can we provide the resources to upgrade? The community could tell us what they envision for MPS What work should we do to engage the community in this discussion so it reflects what the community wants us to do?

Member McLaughlin - very important to have some buy in from the families for the strategic plan - not sure how that would work - but we need to show the families that we include their needs. Also are the hyperlinks working?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes, we should actively involve all members of the community
And yes, all the hyperlinks are included and working.

Member McLaughlin - great, those are really helpful - is this document shared with the hyperlinks so I can digest it over a span of time - color coded and hyperlinks are a lot

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Fostering Collaboration Relationships - actively ensuring all families are welcome

Member McLaughlin - can you click on hyperlink for #2?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes of course. It discusses: enhancing family engagement - open houses, Building Bridges to K, Elementary Middle School Lottery, Middle School BBQ/orientation MFN, Community Schools, PTOs, etc

Member McLaughlin - goal would be to make it available to the community? With the hyperlinks?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes and yes - on the website - and who would be the point person on a particular issue a parent was interested in

Member McLaughlin - can I suggest? How we are actively engaging our families in this process with a 2 way communication? Parent Education piece - Medford SEPAC should be added and lastly data - how do we quantify it? How are we actually qualifying the two way communication?

Member Kreatz - I do remember when you presented it to the school committee - I do think it's a great document - I like the color coding - How can we easily get feedback without developing another taskforce? Maybe send it out and ask for feedback - hyperlinks are great - easy to access - user friendly and can be edited as needed

Member Graham - I think about the need to be a more engaging school district - either we are or aren't - it's a choice we are making - we value the community's thoughts - the roundtables prior to the reopening task force meetings are an excellent example - we could do something like that and do a survey as well for those who can't participate in the roundtables. I think we should pursue that again - what do you all think?

Member McLaughlin - I found a lot of value in the roundtables - you can hear what people really think - I want our community to know that we are all on the same page - I want the community to be able to indicate what the district plan is - maybe creating a graphic - this is what we are going to achieve in 3-5 years

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - this is a multi-year plan - the plan was presented and then covid hit and blew up everything - all of the steps were thrown out and our goal became to just get into a safe and healthy learning environment - what are the additional levels we are doing at the elementary level? - we have to create ways to have kids see each other whether hybrid or fully remote - so they can connect and feel part of a group - one example - are we willing to do the work, yes? To Member Kreatz's point, the total number of roundtables and what it is to present to them, we have a regular meeting scheduled next Monday, so we will speak about listening sessions - a series of listening sessions starting in March - you just got a preview tonight! This is work that we are thinking about - In the spirit of equity we knew with translators, this is not the forum to try to engage with some of our population, so how can we reach the community at large? Maybe so that through more than one way - bandwidth capacity - how to deliver these listening sessions - via levels - elementary, middle and high school - we do have desire and want to communicate with the community - so they are partners with us and collaborate with us - so much here - how much more information do we need to add? We have all this new data and to add it is a tremendous task, but it's our roadmap - we need to be able to go to one place for a general understanding of our district

Member Graham - Listening to all this discussion - and I do strategic planning in my job - Real simple sequence - roundtables, survey - revision - and timelining - What does this look like a year from now, vs. what does it look like 3 years from now? This group came up with the roundtable agendas - something the entire SC can participate in - a quick meeting in Feb to replace the Jan meeting - to flush out an agenda - what do you think about that?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - the listening sessions were not particularly related to strategic plan - looking at the strategic plan I envision that as another set of meetings - so meetings aren't too long and then lose parents attention

Member Graham - do roundtables in April and define agenda at our March meeting?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes, we can work with that - the district is required to have goals embedded in the strategic plan - a lot of information embedded within - it's never final - it's a living document - but it gives the basics of what's happening academically, SEL, etc - topics that might come up regarding budget considerations - so if there is outlier but doesn't align with the

district's strategic plan, we have background to respond - I want to have this posted so we need to move it from the draft to our finalized plan

Member Graham - March 1st scheduled meeting - discuss plans for April roundtables - as well as put forth a potential survey - do roundtables, surveys in April - do revisions in May - it's really ambitious - but if the timeline works...?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes, we want to continue to push the work and we want everyone to know what the district expects

Member Graham - So the April Meeting - communication engagement practices - to set a more specific communication strategy & we can move the website discussion to May meeting

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - yes, it seems ambitious, but we should try to do that

Member Kreatz & McLaughlin agreed

Member Graham - prior to March meeting, I'll put together the revisions of the roundtables - and take a crack at a simple survey as well

Member Graham - Let us move onto Middle School Orientation practices - Kindergarten orientation practices we had a good discussion - exciting we are doing it earlier now so that's great - could we talk briefly about that transition process and what it looks like for this year?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - during my 1st year, and up until pandemic began - middle school student leaders would go to the elementary schools and speak to the students and describe what middle school was like - open houses and tours middle school leaders were the tour guides - presentations in the auditoriums for the rising 5th graders & their parents on what to expect - a lot of opportunities for transition from elementary to middle school, but covid ruined all of that

Member Kreatz - I have attended the open houses/orientations prior to covid, and they improved the experience the year before covid - teachers and parents made presentations - and attendees were split up to visit classrooms - I know the videos were done due to covid - it was a really nice job

Dr. Cushing - The game plan is to start the lottery process after 2nd quarter ends - working with Data Specialist Kim Myles on that right now - opportunity for virtual and possibly in person open houses - right before April Vacation - once teachers are vaccinated, working with Board of Health and Toni Wray - the cookout was the opportunity to bring the 4 elementary schools together into two and this year we hope to do that once again, as well as provide a mini activities

/clubs fair on site that day. Our intention as well is to add in an additional middle school sport - hockey. We are looking at the lottery for the beginning of March

Member Graham - I heard about the Superintendent's lottery roadshow to each elementary school ... can we build upon that to include the opportunity for parents to present middle school questions - have you discussed doing this? Similar to Building Bridges to K program - the lottery process could be presented and then questions could be addressed as well?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - the biggest shift is that students no longer stay with one teacher all day. We are willing to do that

Member Graham - that would be wonderful - 7 seconds left!
Kathy or Melanie do you have any other questions?

Member McLaughlin - sounds good - we will have a little competition - win a prize at the end of the year - LOL - Motion to adjourn, seconded by Member Kreatz

Member Graham - roll call vote - 3 in the affirmative, 0 in the negative

Meeting adjourned at 6:25 PM